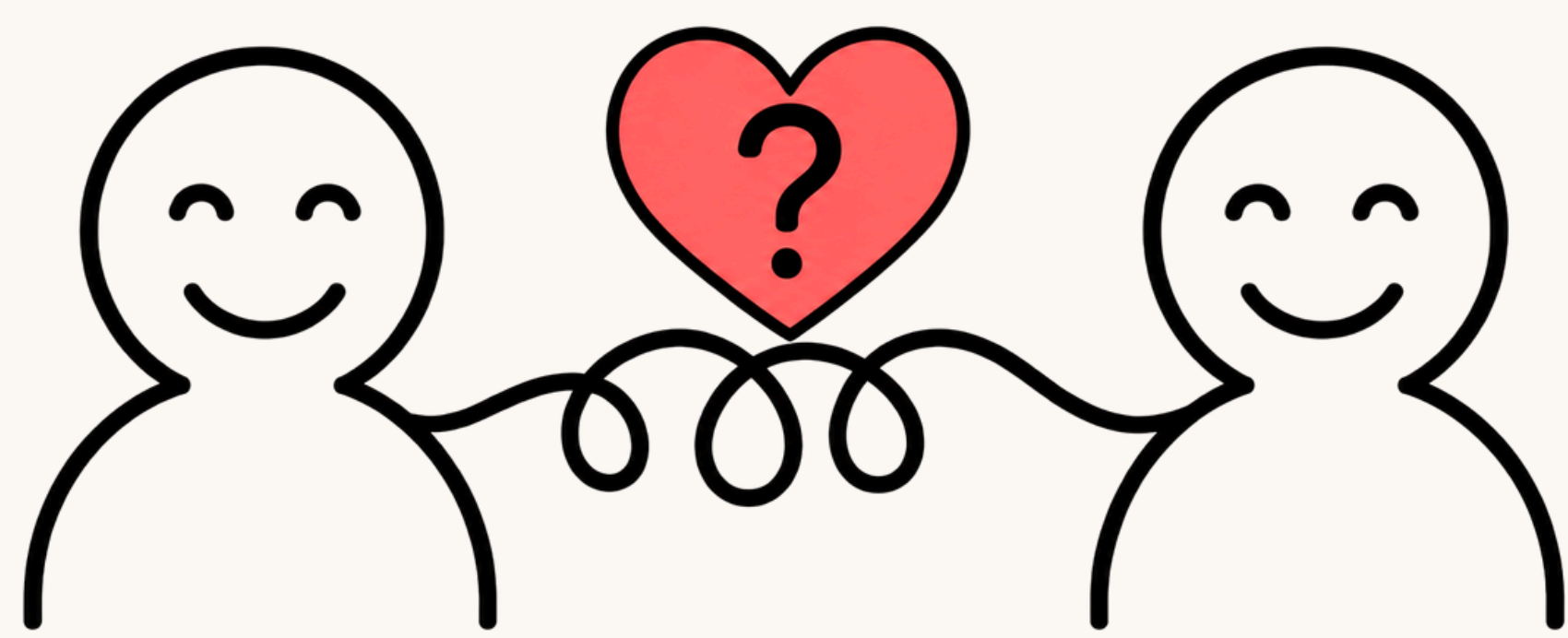


Feeling The Same, Seeing The Same



What does shared emotion mean for love and closeness in romantic couples?

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1 WHY THIS MATTERS

Romantic partners are believed to benefit from "feeling the same," yet research has produced inconsistent and small effects. Studies often blur positive and negative emotions, rarely separate what partners actually share from what is perceived, and measure similarity in many different ways. The result is a fragmented literature on questions that matter for love and closeness.

2 WHAT WE ASKED

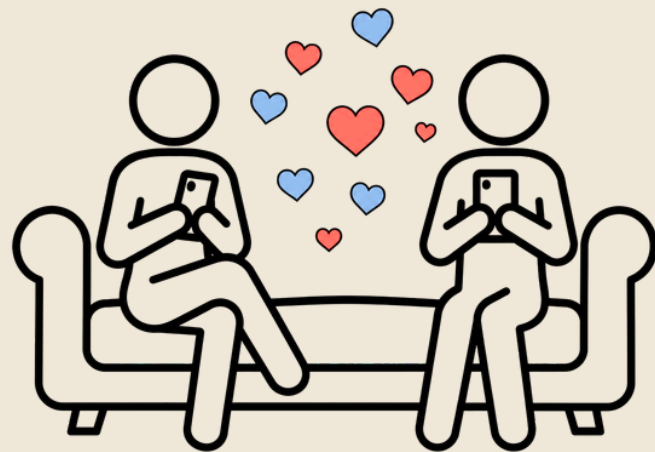
When are couples who feel the same, or who see the same, also more in love or closer? And when does this break down? Does it depend on the emotion's valence, on whether the similarity is in the feeling or in the seeing, and on the timescale or context?

3 HOW WE STUDIED IT

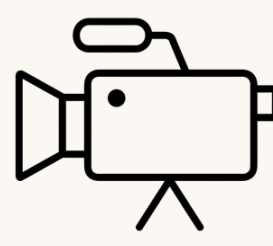
EXPERIENCE SAMPLING 14-day ESM study with 102 couples, with 5–10 prompts per day on their own emotions, their partner's perceived emotions, and how much love they felt.



Multilevel regression predicting momentary love from similarity, with random intercepts and continuous-time AR(1) residuals.



VIDEO-MEDIATED RECALL 98 couples completed positive and a negative lab interactions, then rated their own and partner's emotions on video. Love and closeness were measured after each interaction.



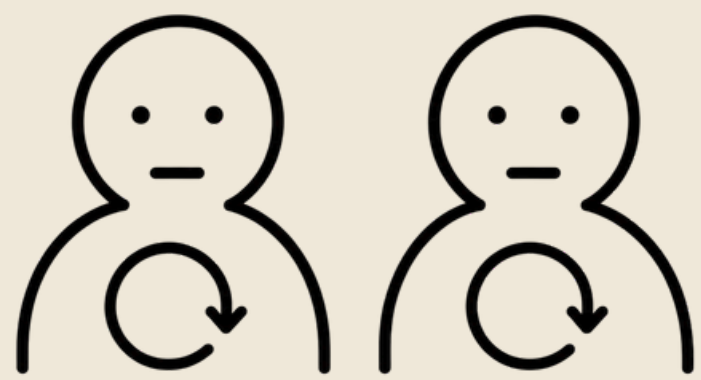
Interaction-level multilevel regression analysis predicting love and closeness from similarity with random intercepts.

POSITIVE AFFECT (PA) AND NEGATIVE AFFECT (NA) RATINGS

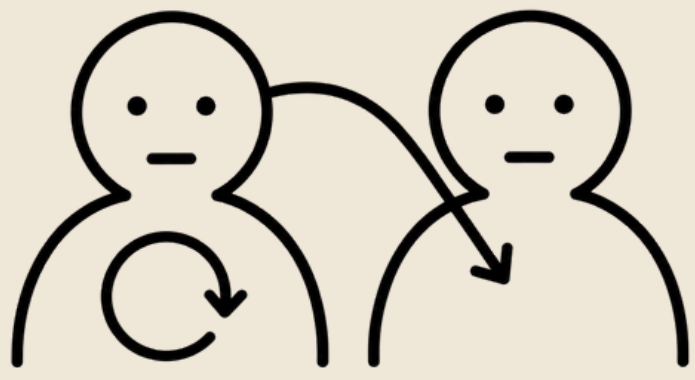
SHARED EMOTION AS PA AND NA SIMILARITY

$$\left(\begin{array}{c} \text{AVERAGE OF} \\ \text{AFFECT RATINGS} \end{array} \right) - \left| \begin{array}{c} \text{DIFFERENCE} \\ \text{BETWEEN RATINGS} \end{array} \right|$$

"joint elevation" "mismatch penalty"

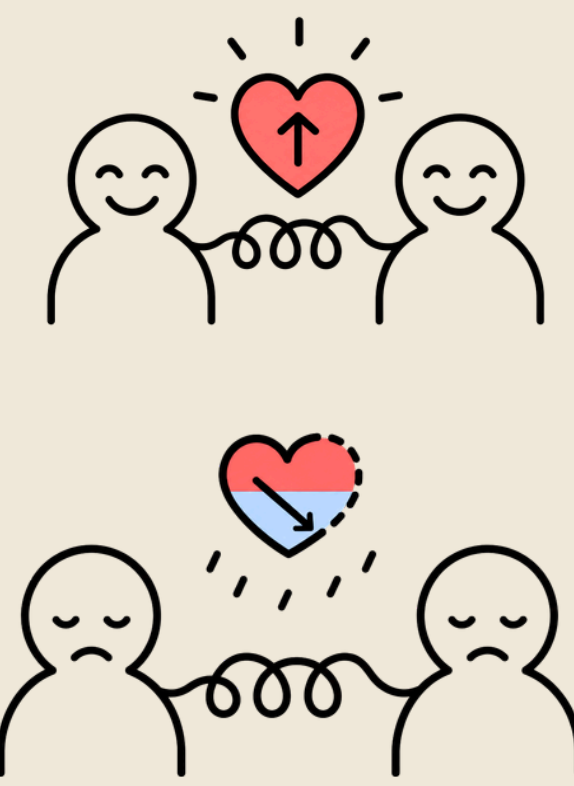


ACTUAL SIMILARITY and **PERCEIVED SIMILARITY**
Two self-reports Self-report + perception



4 WHAT WE FOUND

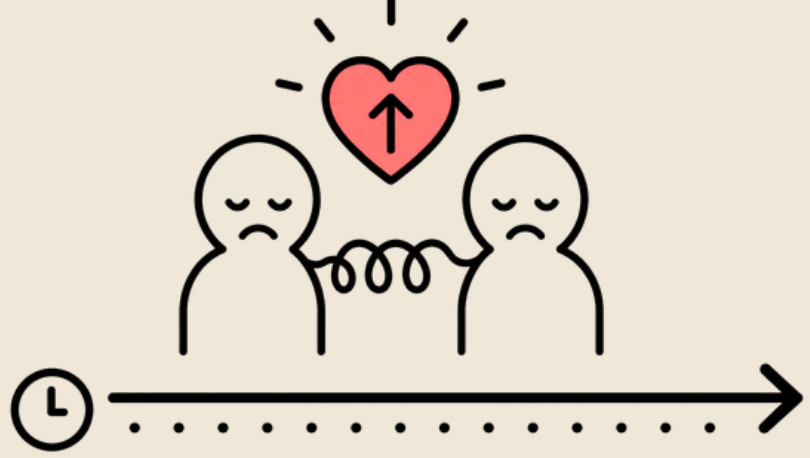
IN THE MOMENT, A MIRROR



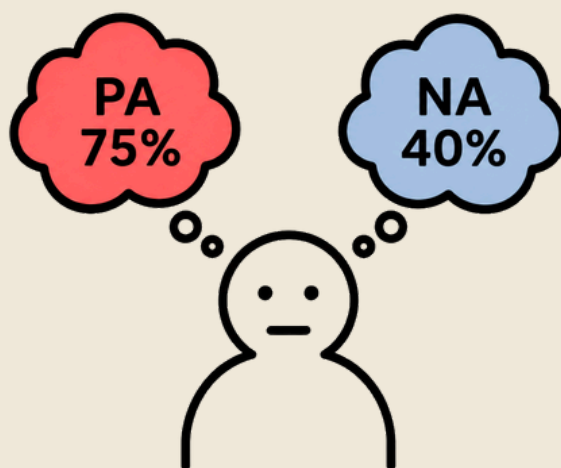
Couples more positively aligned than usual reported higher love. When more negatively aligned, they reported lower love.

OVER TIME, A DIFFERENT STORY

Couples generally more aligned in negativity reported more love, not less.



PERCEPTION CARRIES MUCH OF THE EFFECT



About 75% of the within-moment association between shared positivity and love, and 40% of shared negativity, ran through what was perceived about each other's feelings. The same was not true at the between level or in the lab interactions. Perception seems to work moment to moment.

FEELING UNDERSTOOD SOFTENS THE EFFECT OF SHARED EMOTION



When partners already felt cared for and understood, shared positivity mattered less for love (the relational message was already received), and shared negativity hurt less (being upset together became "being in this together").

NEGATIVITY AMPLIFIES NEGATIVITY (EXPLORATORY)



Shared negative affect was most harmful for love when something negative was already happening, not when it clashed with a positive moment. Across both daily life and the lab, the pattern points to amplification, not mismatch.

5 WHAT IT MEANS

Shared positivity works as expected. Shared negativity is more layered: aversive in the moment, affiliative when routine (likely reflecting understanding in distress, coping together, or simply leading more similar lives). In the moment, much of the link runs through perception: what partners see does much of the work of what they share. Responsiveness substitutes for shared positivity and softens shared negativity.

LEARN MORE

Everything that didn't fit on this poster.

- Full paper, preregistration and summary presentations
- All code and results, fully reproducible
- geert.vandingenen@student.kuleuven.be



SCAN HERE

References

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